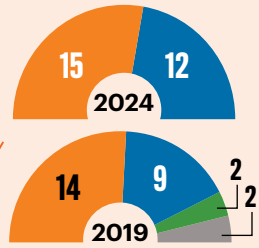
GT ROAD BELT

Total seats: 27

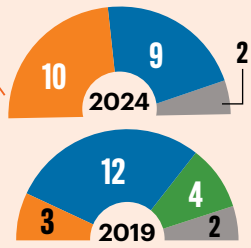


KEY FACTORS

- With the backing of the Punjabi community and Modi as the biggest draw, the BJP swept Karnal and Panipat
- The RSS pushed the nationalism and '*kharchi-parchi*' narratives aggressively
- But while Saini may have won Ladwa, the BJP didn't do too well in his area of influence, losing all other seats in Kurukshetra and even his erstwhile seat Naraingarh in Ambala

DESHWAL REGION

Total seats: 21

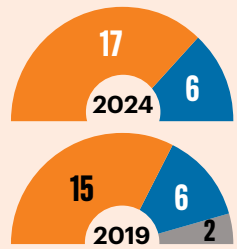


KEY FACTORS

- The BJP strategically fielded forward caste candidates in Jind and Sonipat to counter Hooda's Jat consolidation
- The depleted support base of the Chautalas boosted the Congress's confidence, but even the BJP benefitted
- The BJP-RSS kept reminding the electorate about the possibility of the '*kharchi-parchi*' system (corruption/favouritism in jobs) making a return

AHIRWAL-MEWAT BELT

Total seats: 23



KEY FACTORS

- A strong BJP bastion and RSS's Hindutva push helped counter Muslim consolidation in Nuh and Palwal
- The BJP deflected the blame for poor urban amenities to former ally JJP
- Fielding Union minister Rao Inderjit Singh's daughter Arti and nine other loyalists consolidated the Ahir-Yadav vote bank; the entry of former Congress stalwart Kiran Chaudhary and her daughter proved a boost too

Muslims and Dalits would help build a winning rainbow coalition of castes. To counter it, the BJP cultivated the non-Jat OBCs in the rural areas. These communities had slipped away, with their vote share down from 77 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls to 46 per cent this June. To win them back, the BJP had made its OBC face, Nayab Singh Saini, chief minister in March and made corrections in key policies such as Agniveer, while also dishing out doles and committing to bring more crops under the MSP regime.

The Congress had hoped to sweep the Jat-dominated Bagar and Deshwal belt, especially when both the Chautala family-backed political outfits, Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) and Jannayak Janta Party (JJP), were struggling. Instead, the BJP won 16 of the 40 seats here, seven for the first time.

ANGER MANAGEMENT

While preparing for the Haryana polls, the BJP had to deal with a dual challenge—anger among party leaders against ex-CM Manohar Lal Khattar and, in urban areas, against erstwhile ally, the Dushyant Chautala-led JJP. The RSS and BJP collaborated to reduce the impact. Party candidates in urban areas accepted the shortcomings, blamed them on the JJP and cited the same as the reason for dumping them. The JJP was reduced to less than 1 per cent of the popular vote, and did not even come second in any seat in the state. Ex-deputy CM Dushyant lost his deposit in the Uchana Kalan seat.

THE BJP FIELDED 60 FRESH FACES IN A BID TO ASSUAGE THE LOCAL ANGER. IT PAID OFF, AS IT WON 22 SEATS FOR THE FIRST TIME

Simultaneously, the party increased Saini's visibility among rural voters, and had him visit the homes of disgruntled party leaders to address the Khattar issue. The BJP also fielded 60 fresh faces this time to assuage the local anger. It paid off, as the party won 22 seats for the first time. Likewise, the party decided to accommodate mass leaders in ticket distribution. So Union minister Krishan Pal Gurjar got tickets for five of his loyalists, as did Rao Inderjit Singh for daughter Arti Singh Rao and nine more loyalists.

In Haryana, just like the Jats, even the Gujjars, Ahirs and other OBC leaders had been feeling ignored under the Khattar dispensation. The BJP strategically allocated 22 seats to the OBCs, compared to the Congress's 20, and allowed its satraps to run the campaign.

The Congress decision to give tickets to Muslim candidates in five seats—Yamunanagar, Hathin, Ferozepur Jhirka, Punahana and Nuh—may have worked locally, but it 'counter-polarised' the voters in other areas of the Ahirwal belt in the state. The presence of 2023 riot accused Mamman Khan as a Congress candidate also helped the BJP narrative. The party won 17 of the 23 seats in the region, including Ateli, which Arti Singh